

“We Are Not Easily Fooled Anymore”

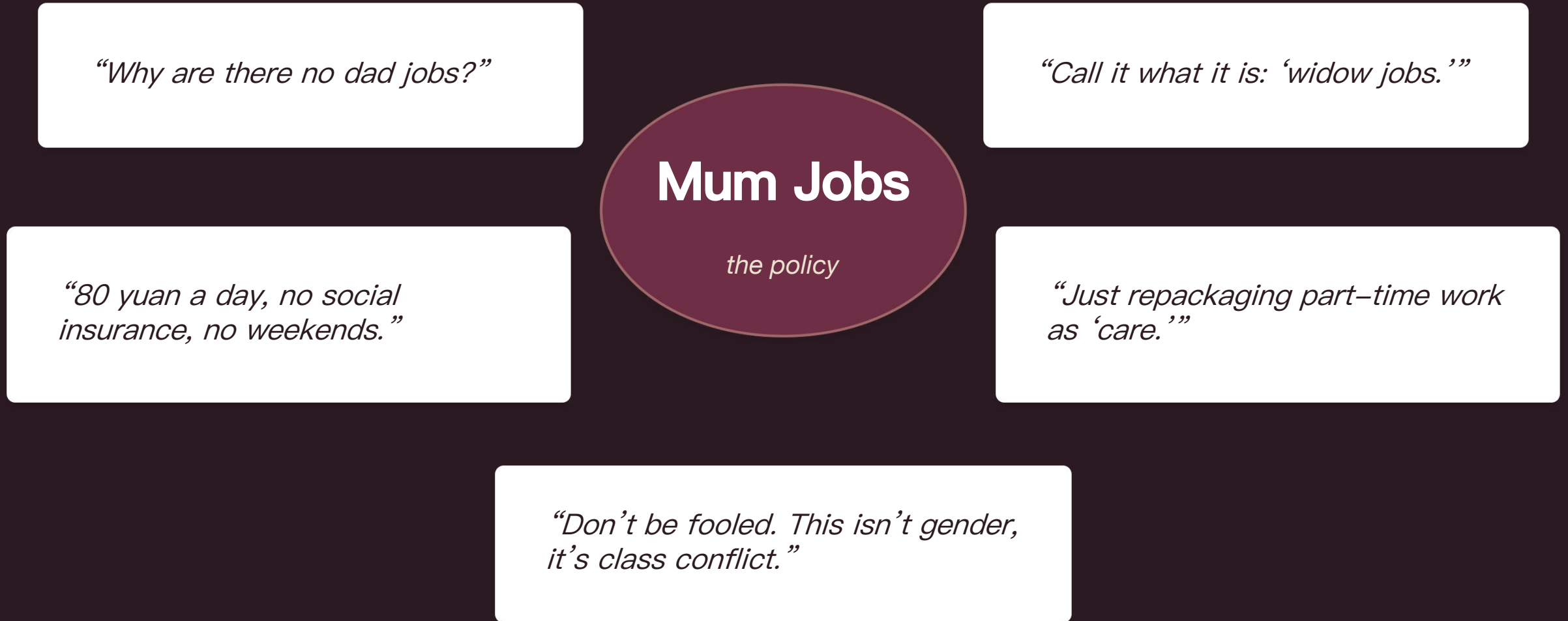
Discursive Practices and Digital Activism Around China’s Mum Jobs Policy on Rednote

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Feminist Counter-Publics and Digital Solidarities

Promoted as “friendly to women.” The users read it very differently.



One official frame. Many overlapping readings: gender, labour, class.

Background

From birth control to a “fertility-friendly society”

China shifted from restricting births to encouraging them. Yet in 2024 there were only 9.54 million births, with negative population growth.

Mum jobs (Hubei, May 2025)

A government-encouraged scheme: enterprises create flexible positions for mothers with children under twelve. Promoted as a benefit for women.

The puzzle: a policy framed as a benefit met not gratitude but organised, large-scale pushback. How, and to what end?



Why Rednote?

79% women.

After feminist spaces on other platforms were squeezed, the conversation moved here.

Women interpreting a policy aimed at them.

Framework and the gap



Counter-publics (Fraser, 1990; Warner, 2002)

Groups pushed to the margins of the dominant public build their own discursive space and circulate oppositional readings. A public is held together by that circulation of talk.

THE GAP

Counter-public research tends to study visible resistance, or platforms made for public expression. This case is different: a platform treated as **non-political**, and a target **wrapped in goodwill**. How does a counter-public take a policy sold as a benefit, pull it apart, and keep that critique going?

Research questions

RQ1

What main themes emerge in users' discussion of the policy, and what concerns do they reveal?

RQ2

What discursive strategies do users employ to construct critical interpretations, and how do these practices manifest digital activism?

Data and method

20,173

comments

Rednote · June 2025

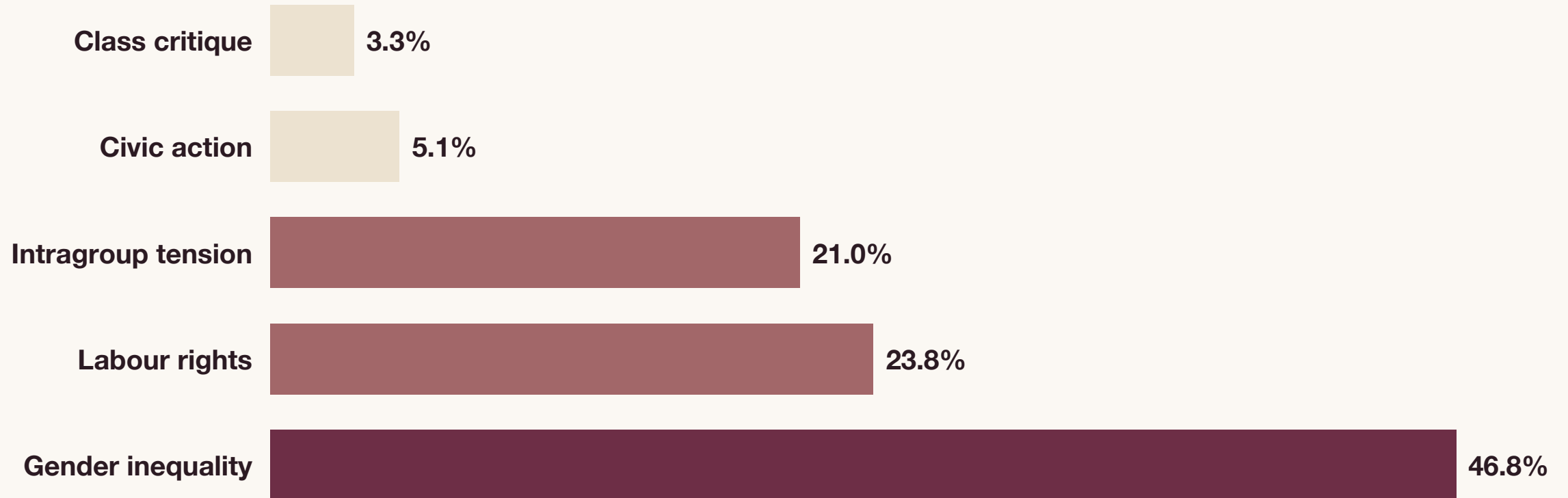
Step 1 · Locate

BERTopic identifies the main themes across the corpus; semantic networks show the structure within each.

Step 2 · Interpret

Critical discourse analysis (Fairclough, 1992) reads how users construct and circulate critique.

The five themes



Gender dominates, but the conversation does not stay there.



Finding 1 · “Why are there no dad jobs?”

A question that does not ask. It critiques.

Exposes the assumption

Invoking a job category that does not exist makes visible the premise that childcare is only the mother’s problem.

Names the motherhood penalty

Mum jobs institutionalise the link between motherhood and precarious, low-paid work, locking mothers into a secondary labour market.

Defends reproductive autonomy

Assuming mothers should want flexible work strips legitimacy from those who want to keep their careers. The deeper claim: the right to remain a full participant after birth.



Finding 2 • Strategic de–gendering

Some users deliberately drop the gender frame and pivot to class.

Intragroup tension

Who can afford to refuse a mum job?

Women with options reject it to protect careers; women without options need the income. The familiar dilemma: critique the structure without blaming the woman caught in it.

The pivot, in users' words

reposted en masse

“Don’t be fooled ... this is class conflict. What they least fear is the anger being shifted onto men–versus–women.”

The move: users name the gender frame as a trap and switch to class and “this hurts dads too,” both to dodge the men-versus-women split and to widen the coalition. Read in a setting where gender talk is increasingly fraught, the pivot works as a way to keep the critique alive, not as class consciousness.



Finding 3 • How resistance was done

Sustaining a counter-public on a platform that constrains it.



Counter-naming

“Widow jobs,” “dead-father jobs.” A small linguistic act that exposes the absent father in the policy’s design.



Manual reposting

Rednote gives no repost button, so users copy and paste by hand. Content is replicable, but the platform withholds the tool, so they supply the labour themselves.



Online to offline

Users circulated the 12345 government hotline and taught each other how to file formal complaints, turning talk into institutional pressure.

Discussion and contribution

1

Sustaining critique when the platform won't help

Rednote forbids reposting and censors discussion, yet the critique holds, carried by users' own discursive strategies rather than by anything the platform's design provides.

2

Creative resistance, made visible

Renaming, manual amplification, and routing online energy into formal channels are the concrete practices that keep the counter-public alive.

3

Fertility policy as a contested site

The policy becomes a place where contradictions across gender, labour, and the state surface and can be challenged.

“

“We are not easily fooled anymore.”

They renamed the policy, copied each other's words by hand to beat the algorithm, and argued over who counts as “us.” That collective awakening is itself the change, before any policy moves.

In that sense, this case speaks to what brings this panel together: how counter-publics form, and how fragile their solidarities can be.

Thank you

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Questions are welcome at yi_zhu0908@outlook.com